Vodafone was not liable to pay the tax but now the government was seeking to amend tax laws retrospectively to bring Vodafone-like deals in the tax net. When an industry delegation met the prime minister to raise the issue, Dr Singh seemed helpless. ‘I will try and speak to Pranabda and see what is possible,’ was the weak assurance. Delayed land clearances, contentious tax amendments, FIRs against leading industrialists, high expenditure on social welfare programmes in a period of low growth—bombarded with such negatives, corporate India was desperately looking for their white knight. When Modi began speaking of less government, more governance, it was just what they wanted to hear. ‘He speaks our language. Five more years of the UPA and the India story is finished,’ is how a corporate leader explained his unstinted support for Modi.

Businessmen are usually careful in articulating their political preferences. At any post-budget show, the men in suits tend to give the finance minister eight or nine out of ten. But ahead of the elections, the reticence was slowly disappearing. At a closed-door meeting in Mumbai called by a prominent business leader to garner support for Modi in early 2014, there was virtually a full house.

The one industrialist who was seen to be firmly in the Modi camp was Gujarat-based entrepreneur Gautam Adani. Like Ambani, Adani, too, had been in the cross hairs of the AAP attack. AAP leaders had questioned Modi’s proximity to Adani and accused the Gujarat chief minister of ‘gifting’ him land at the Mundra port site at well below market rates and by disregarding environment norms.

That Modi and Adani shared a ‘special relationship’ is beyond doubt. In the aftermath of the 2002 riots, when Modi was confronted by senior industry voices at a CII conference, Adani had stood by him and set up a parallel body of Gujarati businessmen, ‘The Resurgent Group of Gujarat’ (see chapter 1). News reports claimed that in the decade of Modi’s rule in Gujarat, Adani’s assets had grown twelve-fold to over Rs 35,000 crore, with interests in ports, power, coal and edible oil. At Adani’s son’s marriage, Modi had attended almost all the ceremonies, including flying down to Goa for the celebrations.